A Man Named Dave

By Dave Pelzer

Nothing could have prepared me for seeing my father. "My father, Stephen Pelzer, he's here? I mean, he's okay and he's *in this hospital* on *this floor*. Right?" I blurted out.

Steve, *the nurse*, began to reply but raised a hand to his mouth as if to first collect his thoughts. "Man, we've been waiting on you. Yeah, kid, your father's here, and . . . yeah, he's on this floor. But chill for a sec. There's a few things you need to know."

I rolled my eyes as if to say, *Yeah, yeah, come on, out with it.* "So . . . I nagged, "What's the deal? What happened? He fell down, broke an arm? What is it? When does he check out?"

My ears picked up the faint sound of a hacking cough. Without thinking, I spun to the right and marched into the room next to the nurses' station. Before me, shaking like a leaf in a flimsy hospital gown, was the skeleton-like figure of my father. He seemed

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to be using whatever strength he could muster to make it to the bathroom. By the vacant look in his eyes I could tell he had no idea of who I was, or even that someone else was in the room with him. Coming around behind him, I slung his arm around my shoulder and helped him into the bathroom. "Are you all right? Are you okay? Dad," I gently whispered, "it's David. Dad," I said in a firmer tone, "can you hear me?" Father's only response was a raspy exhale. "Dad? Hey, Dad! Can you . . . do you hear me? It's me, David. *Say something*, anything. Dad?"

"We need to talk," *Steve* said without the slightest trace of embarrassment.

INTRODUCTION

Dave Pelzer was the victim of unbelievable child abuse. His mother denied him food and clothing, locked him in the basement, and told her son she could kill him any time she wanted to – and nearly did. And Dave's father? He never intervened. By the time Dave was 12, the state had removed him from his home and placed him in foster care. But even years after he was rescued, his life remained a continual struggle. In this scene, Dave tries to reconnect with his dying father. A Man Named Dave by Dave Pelzer

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When we were both outside of the room, Steve carefully closed the heavy oak door. "What's wrong with him?" I demanded. "What type of medication do you have him on? How come he doesn't recognize me? Is it the drugs? How long will it be until he gets better and gains some weight? When do you expect him to be released?"

"Hey, man," Steve said, raisng his hand, "give it a rest. "Didn't your mother tell you . . . ? You don't know, do you?"

"Know what? If I knew, I wouldn't be bugging you!" I sarcastically shot back. "Just tell me, what in the heck is going on? Please!" I now begged.

Leading me down the corridor, Steve searched for a more private setting. At the end of the hallway, he stopped to offer me a chair. I refused, feeling the need to stand. "It was about four months ago when your father was admitted - Your father ... he wanted to keep things discreet. Anyway, it was only after we ran all the tests that our diagnosis was confirmed. David, your father has cancer. I'm afraid it's

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terminal. He's in the advanced stages. I'm sorry." Steve reached out for my hands. "There is nothing we can do. David," Steve said in a deliberate, slow voice, gripping me by the shoulders, "your father ... *he's not going to make it.* "

"You mean ... you're saying he's going to die? *My dad* is going to die? No way!" I shook my head in complete denial. "Can't you give him a shot of something ... or I thought there's some kind of chemo treatment. If it's money you need . . . just don't let him die. Not now. Please!" I begged, as if he alone decided the fate of my father.

"David, listen, chill for a sec. I don't know, *no one knows* exactly how long your father has, but," he emphasized in a strong tone, "the thing I do know for certain is this: *your father is not going to make it.* And there is nothing, *nothing,* that you, I, or anyone else can do about it. I am sorry. I truly am."

I simply stood in front of Steve like a zombie. I wanted to release everything and cry. A heartbeat later, I suppressed the urge. "Four months?" I asked

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incoherently. "You're telling me my dad's been here that long? How long has he been ... like he is now? Why can't he talk? Is he doped up? I mean, he acts like he doesn't even recognize me .... I don't, I just don't understand," I stammered.

"Well," Steve began, sliding a chair for me next to his, "your father checked in a few months ago. Since then his condition has rapidly deteriorated. The growth was primarily centered on the side of his neck, but has since spread to his throat. He is on medication. That is the reason he lacks discernment. If we take him off the 'meds,' his understanding might improve, but the pain would be unbearable."

"So . . . he'll never be able to say anything again? Ever ... ?" I asked as my voice trailed off.

"That is correct. Not any longer," Steve replied, nodding his head.

I still refused to admit I could be losing Father. *"SO* ... what can I do?" I asked. Why doesn't he look at me? Does he know, I mean, is he capable of

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knowing I'm even here?"

Steve sighed as if growing tired of my endless stream of questions. "For the most part, it's fifty-fifty at best. He seems more coherent in the morning but, for the most part, no more than a few minutes at a time. He's at the stage when he drifts off quite a bit . . . I know it's a lot to deal with," he stated, shaking his head, "but first things first. Spend time with your father . . . That's priority one. I can walk you through the paperwork and all the other things you need to do when the time comes. For now, just spend time with your dad."

"But ... I, ah, I don't know what to say," I replied. "I mean, he doesn't even know that I'm with him."

"Your father doesn't show it, but he's scared. He knows he's not going to make it. Anything you can do would mean the world to him. He's all alone in there." Steve gently scolded, *"You* have to do this! Just . . . just reminisce about all those good times you spent together. Keep him 'up.' He'll know."

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Yeah, all those good times, I said mockingly to myself. Not knowing what to say or do, I felt paralyzed. For the first time in nearly two years, I finally had the chance to be with my father. As I stared at him, I suddenly realized I knew nothing about him. As long as I could remember, my visits with Father had probably amounted to less than ten, maybe twenty hours together. Without warning tears began to swell in my eyes. "I, ah ... I tried to write. I mean, I wrote ... but I wasn't sure of your address. I'm sorry. I truly am. I didn't know. I would have come sooner. I just didn't know."

I turned away to compose myself. The last thing I wanted was to lose it in front of my father. Out of nowhere, a memory of Father and me, when I was a preschooler, sprang from my mind. I sat on Father's bed while tucking the sheet under his frail back. "You may not remember," I began, "but when I was four, maybe five, all of us went to the Russian River .... Early one evening, after dinner, you stepped out for a walk, and I tagged along behind you. . . . I

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snuck out and walked behind you, tracing your steps. I had those little Forest Ranger boots, and I tried to keep up while being as quiet as I could. I think I made it five, maybe ten feet away from the cabin, when you heard me. You spun around so fast I thought you were going to bite my head off, but you - You simply extended your giant hand and scooped my fingers into yours .... Then, without a word, you let me walk with you.

"I have to say, as a kid that was pretty cool. At the time, between Ron, Stan, and me, to be able to hog a few minutes alone with you, well, back then that was all I talked about after our walk. It was that summer when I knew that's where I wanted to live. The trees, the river, the smell, those precious moments with you, that's when I knew. Back then, with you, I was safe. Back then you were my superhero; you were my Superman. I know it sounds kinda dumb," I scoffed, "but that was the only time you held my hand. When *you* wanted to be with *me.*"

"When I was at The House, I remember all

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those times you'd come home from the fire station for just a few minutes to check in on me. Mother didn't know it, but I made sure I timed your arrival when I was washing the dishes so I could actually see you. Sometimes I got too far behind with my chores and ... well, you know Mother ... I paid the price when you were gone. I knew she'd never allow you to go down to the basement, so I'd wash the dishes over and over until I heard you open the front door." I paused to stare directly into Father's eyes. "You saved me. Even though it was only for a few seconds alone in the kitchen, it made all the difference. Sometimes if you brushed against me, I'd breathe in your Old Spice cologne. You were my invisible force field. I'm just sorry you, the boys-everyone-had to deal with so much crap. I somehow thought I'd be able to make it up to you-to everyone.

"You see, Dad, I knew. I always knew you came back to the house for me. And now, no matter what happens, I'm here for you. No matter what anybody says, I'll protect your honor."

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"As a kid, I was always proud of you being a fireman. You looked so cool in your dark blue uniform, it was then that I knew I wanted to be a fireman. Dad, I asked, "Dad, do you ... do ... do you still have your badge? Your fireman's badge?" *(to audience)* "It's the only thing he has that showed what he did. After everything, it's all he has."

His head continued to twitch, but now more to the right, while his eyes strained as if telling me to look into ... "The closet!" I exclaimed. "You want me to look in the closet?" I jumped from the bed and flung open the door. I gave Father a slight nod before my hands patted down his coat. I felt a small bulge. Without looking I yanked out a small, black-leather casing. Searching his eyes, I understood. I whispered into his ear, praying he could hear me, "As God is my witness, I will protect and keep your badge. I will carry it as a sign of honor."

As Father's grip eased, I could tell he had fallen asleep. Before his fingers could slip away, I kissed his hand. Turning toward the door, I saw

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Steve.

"He'll be able to rest now. You've made him very happy. He told me months ago, when he checked in, that he wanted you to have it. Today was a good day for your father. A very good day."

TRANSITION: - ***These words are not in the text of the book:*** *I spent a few days at the hospital, talking to my dad and listening to him too. On the fourth day, when I arrived at the hospital, I met Steve at the entrance to Father's room.*

I knew by Steve's forced smile all I needed to know. "David, you need to understand ... sometimes they can't ... they won't go until they know the ones they love will be fine. He's in pain. You have to tell him you'll be fine. You have to let him go. He won't pass until you do this. Ease his suffering. It's the right thing for him. It's the proper thing to do. He won't pass until ..."

I fled to the far end of the hall, where I found a wooden bench. Clasping my hands together, I prayed. "I've never really asked you for much. And you know what I've been through. I guess I thought I could save him .... So, if you could grant me this ... if there's no way

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that he can get better ... then take him. Ease his pain and take my dad. Amen." Not knowing what to do next, I wiped away my tears, cleared my mind, and made my way to Father's room.

Standing by his bed, I took Father's trembling hand. From behind my eyes I could feel the pressure build, and fought to bury the pain.

"I, ah, got ... some great news," I lied. "The doctor says everything's gonna be fine ... and that ... they can have you up and outta here real soon." Peering into Father's face, I stated with confidence, "I didn't tell you this before, but I got a home on the Russian River. It's got knotty pine walls and ceilings. A stone fireplace, your own room. It's always warm and sunny. It's on the river, and when the sun goes down, the water's as smooth as glass. At night you can smell the redwood trees ... it's a piece of heaven, Dad. Heaven. And in the summer ... we can go to San Fran and catch a game at Candlestick-just like you always said we'd do. We can be like a real father and son. Just the two of us. Everything's gonna be fine. We can be together

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... and live at peace. We got a home, a real home. No more fighting, no more troubles. You just relax and ... I'll take care of you . . . I'll take care of everything."

I broke off when I felt Father's trembling fingers clutch my hand. Never before in my entire life had both of us looked deep into each other. His dark eyes were perfectly clear as they bore into mine. I could somehow feel the immense shame, loneliness, sorrow, and pain in Father's gaze. "I've always been proud of you. You've always been my hero. And as your son, I swear to God, one day I will, *I will* make you proud. I always have and always will love you, Father. Now you relax ... and I'll meet you at the river."

Then, like so many years ago, as he had that summer when we strolled together at the Russian River, my father winked at me before he slipped away.

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